

SLOPPY - Social Media Task - Increasing vs. Flat (#172255)

Author(s)

This pre-registration is currently anonymous to enable blind peer-review.
It has one author.

Pre-registered on: 04/24/2024 01:29 PM (PT)

1) Have any data been collected for this study already?

No, no data have been collected for this study yet.

2) What's the main question being asked or hypothesis being tested in this study?

In a cue-learning task in which none of the cues influence the outcomes, people who learned in the presence of a positive exogenous trend (vs. no trend) will be more confident that the cues did have an influence the outcomes.

3) Describe the key dependent variable(s) specifying how they will be measured.

We will measure three dependent variables:

- a) Participant's belief that the cues influenced the outcomes. This DV is the average of four items: "Changing the features of posts had an impact on the engagement they received", "Some features of posts resulted in stronger engagement than others", "Overall, the features of posts mattered for how much engagement they received", "The engagement received didn't seem affected by the features of the posts" (reverse-coded), all measured on 5-point scales ("Strongly disagree", "Somewhat disagree", "Neither agree nor disagree", "Somewhat agree", "Strongly agree")
- b) Participant's subjective understanding of the relationship between cues and outcomes. This DV is the average of three items: "I managed to learn which features of posts (if any) had an impact on the engagement they received", "I understood how the features of posts relate to their engagement", and "I know which features affected the engagement of posts, and in which direction", all measured on 5-point scales ("Strongly disagree", "Somewhat disagree", "Neither agree nor disagree", "Somewhat agree", "Strongly agree")
- b) Subjective likelihood that "best" practices will outperform "worst" practices. Participants will describe the features of posts that they believe are predictive of "strong" and "weak" engagement. They will then report the probability that a post with "strong" engagement features will outperform a post with "weak" engagement features, on a 50-100% scale (in 5% increments). This measure is incentive-compatible: The participants who give the correct answer (50%) will be entered a lottery to win 50GBP.

4) How many and which conditions will participants be assigned to?

The only condition of interest is the trend of the outcomes: Participants will be randomly assigned to the "Increasing" condition (in which outcomes tend to increase over time) or the "Flat" condition.

In addition, the outcomes that participants see in each of these conditions will be randomly chosen out of five different replicates. We do not expect any impact of this factor.

5) Specify exactly which analyses you will conduct to examine the main question/hypothesis.

We will compare our three pre-registered dependent variables across conditions using independent sample t-tests.

6) Describe exactly how outliers will be defined and handled, and your precise rule(s) for excluding observations.

We will measure the amount of time participants spend on the cue-learning task, and exclude all participants who completed the task in less than 50 seconds.

7) How many observations will be collected or what will determine sample size? No need to justify decision, but be precise about exactly how the number will be determined.

In the hope of reaching 400 valid participants after exclusions, we will collect 440 responses.

8) Anything else you would like to pre-register? (e.g., secondary analyses, variables collected for exploratory purposes, unusual analyses planned?)

We will conduct exploratory analysis on the choice patterns of participants during the game. Specifically, we will check if participants in the "Increasing" condition were quicker to converge on a set of attributes (defined by the number of attributes that participants change from one round to another, between 0 and 5) as the game went on.

We will also explore participants' beliefs in what are "strong" and "weak" engagement practices. If participants do not have strong priors, we should expect to see that a good number of the 108 possible combinations are represented in the participants' answers.